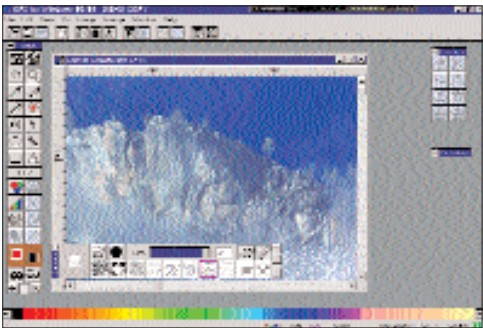


How easy is it really?

When you hear the name of any professional software, do you get the jitters and start thinking that it would be impossible for you to work with such high-end software?

Well, if this is the case, then relax. It is not so difficult to learn such software really. One will need some sort of formal training and patience, of course, to get the hang of how the software works and what you can actually achieve with it. Mastering the art of digital imagery is not fundamentally as difficult as it is made out to be.

In the test we discovered that QFX7 was the most difficult software to work with. There is no way a novice or even an experienced user can go ahead and work with this software in spite of the fundamentals being the same.



QFX7 has an unintuitive Interface

This software performs dual functions: it is an image editor as well as a program for illustrations. QFX7 has two modes, the ‘paint mode’ and the ‘draw mode’, which the user has to constantly keep on juggling between if he has to edit the image or draw any diagrams. And then comes the interface. The developers of this package seem to be completely insensitive to the principles of interface design. This software does possess some reasonably good image editing capabilities but looking at the interface, we doubt if anybody would like to work with it. The amateurish style of buttons and the skimpy toolbar would put any serious digital artist off, not to mention the confused amateur.

Adobe Photoshop’s interface, in contrast, provides a floating toolbar with well-defined icons as well as a horizontal toolbar, which lists extra functions of every tool. This puts the functionality of extra features at your fingertips, the way it should be.

The interfaces of Gimp and Paint Shop Pro will not appeal to the aesthetically inclined. Gimp, as it comes from the Linux world, looks quite different from any other Windows program. The menu rendering style, the pointer arrow twisted inverse and the floating toolbars that just fall plop into the whole soup of an interface do not read ‘user friendly’ in any way.

Paint Shop Pro’s toolbar and icons appear

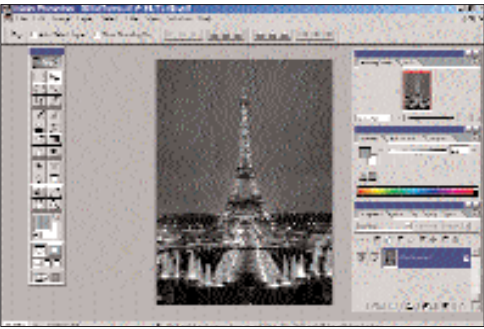
TEST PROCESS

We tested the software for the features offered. In particular, we tested for installation size and memory consumption, ease of use and features. The last factor always forms an extremely important part of any software. Here, we considered the following features: the facility to work with layers, the number of predefined set of filters, masking, twain compatibility (the functionality of directly picking up images from the scanner), the ability to convert images to high resolution, the facility of adding gradients to your work, and the ability to change colour channels from RGB to CMYK mode or vice versa.

We also looked for drawing tools that allow inclusion of diagrams in

the work without having to minimise the photo editing software and open a separate drawing software. To check how easy the software really was while working, we tried importing a JPEG photograph and working on it with various tools in the software. We checked whether the software supported the common file formats such as TIFF, JPG, GIF, PSD, PNG, and so on.

Most users tend to get confused by the plethora of features provided in professional software. Hence, while evaluating this feature, we checked whether it explained the basic operations of the software and if it provided in-depth examples that would be helpful for novices.



Photoshop 6: an easy-to-use and intuitive interface

very bland and somewhat old when compared to the smooth and suave Photoshop icons and toolbars.

To put it simply, nothing comes close to Photoshop when it comes to the interface.

Features

Layers: With the support of layers one can work with multiple pictures on different layers in the same window. It is easy to hide the objects placed on every individual layer and if the software supports blending capabilities, one can change the overall look of the picture by applying options such as soft light, dissolve, multiply, hard light, etc. Thus, with multiple layering, one can do wonders with the photographs.



The Layer Style in Photoshop 6

QFX7 takes a beating again by providing layer support only in the draw mode and by not providing any support where it is needed the most—the

Find it on
digit
interactive

More Info on
the test process and the
products tested.
Check out
Mindware

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